

Adoption



A judge speaks from the bench, glad. A family gathers a child in — father, mother, son — faces up, unashamed. The law and the hug are both in the frame.

Before you gather

- Read Day 23, Adoption, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Galatians 4:4–7 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

When did someone give you a place you had not earned: a seat, a team, a name, a home?

Leader. Brought in, not earned. The book already asked about belonging, conflict in the church, and loneliness. Leave those three alone. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Adoption is not God pretending you cleaned yourself up. Jesus came to redeem those under the law. God receives believers as sons through Him, because He wanted them. A name, an inheritance, and a Father. Sons do not earn the house.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Adoption means God welcomes believers into His family as dear children, giving us full rights and love as heirs in Christ.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek huiothesia — placement as a son, the legal act of adoption.

MEMORY VERSE · EPHESIANS 1:4–5

In love he predestined us for adoption to himself as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will.

Together, open the flashcard for Adoption. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Galatians 4:4–7

Galatians 4:4–7 moves a person from slave to son to heir, and puts “Abba, Father” in the mouth. That is adoption in one paragraph. It is not the journal assignment. The Son redeems. Then God receives.

But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons. And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, “Abba! Father!” So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Trace the order. What did the Son do, what do we receive, and what does the Spirit cry? **CORE**

Leader. Born of woman, born under the law, He redeems. We receive adoption as sons. The Spirit cries “Abba, Father.” Sonship follows redemption. It is not a mood we work up. Ephesians 1; Romans 8; Galatians 4.

2. In verse 7, what is the difference between a slave in the house and a son?

Leader. A slave may work the property. A son inherits it. Duty without adoption is not the gospel. God receives believers as sons through Jesus.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 8:15–17: the Spirit does not lead us back into fear, and children are heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with Him. How does adoption answer fear, and why does Paul join sonship to sharing Christ’s sufferings? **CORE**

Leader. Abba answers slave-fear. Adoption is not a promise that the family skips pain. It is a promise you do not face it as an orphan. We follow the Spirit by the Word He has given, not by a

feeling that we are in the family today and out tomorrow.

4. Ephesians 1:5 says this was “according to the purpose of his will,” in love. What happens to assurance if we think we were adopted because we were the promising child?

Leader. The purpose was His. The love was His. Promising children wear themselves out trying to stay adoptable. He did not wait until we cleaned ourselves up.

5. John 1:12–13: He gave the right to become children of God to those who received Him, born not of the will of the flesh. Who near you still thinks they must earn a seat at the Father’s table?

Leader. A child, a friend, a new believer. A word of welcome must not add a condition Christ did not add. They come to Jesus. They do not clean up first.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Adoption means God receives believers as His sons and heirs through Jesus, not after they clean themselves up.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Save a real seat at your table for someone who belongs nowhere obvious. Welcome them before they earn it. Tell them God receives

people as His children through Jesus, not after they clean themselves up.

Leader. One meal is enough. Welcome them. Do not turn them into a project. The sentence is the gospel of adoption, not advice to try harder at home. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank the Father that believers are sons through Jesus, not staff trying to keep a job in the house.
2. Ask Him to drive out the fear that He will put you out.
3. Pray for someone who has only known fathers as fear, that they would hear of the Father Jesus trusted.

Before you stumble

The courtroom can hurt someone whose family is not a good parable. Say this at the start: the doctrine does not depend on your earthly father being kind. God is the Father Jesus trusted, not a larger version of a wound. “Sons” in Galatians 4 is the legal standing of every believer, women and men. Daughters are not second-class. The word is the rights of the heir. Say so. Do not force a family story. Do not lead a slow, silent “Abba” exercise. Pray as children because Scripture puts that word in the church’s mouth.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a last name does on a jersey or a form. Then ask what it means that God gives His name through Jesus before we perform.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 15:22–24, the robe, the ring, and the feast. Week 2 used the embrace. Here, notice the signs of sonship given, not earned. Two minutes, if you want the picture. The Father runs. The son does not purchase the ring.

